

**THE PROTO-SEMITIC ROOT ʔil-:
PROGENITOR, AUTHORITY, SACRALIZATION
A Critique of the Term "God" as an Anachronism in Semitology**

Monograph

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ABSTRACT

This monograph proposes a radical reinterpretation of the proto-Semitic root ʔil-, which underlies all Semitic designations for "god": Akkadian ilu(m), Ugaritic ʾil, Biblical Hebrew

ʿēl/ʿelōhīm, Aramaic ʿēlāhā, and Arabic Allāh. The central thesis holds that the term "god," applied to this root in academic literature since Gesenius (1829), constitutes a methodological anachronism: it describes the result of a multi-millennial process of sacralization rather than the original meaning of the root.

The original meaning of the root ʿil- is reconstructed as a social role: the progenitor of the clan, the first in the line of generation. This role conferred authority upon its bearer during life and became the object of sacralization after death. Direct textual evidence for the reconstruction includes: the Ugaritic text KTU 1.17 I 25–33, where the deceased father of a specific individual becomes ʿilib; the Ugaritic theophoric names ʿabʿil ("my father is ʿil"), ʿaḥʿil ("my brother is ʿil"), ʿmʿil ("my kinsman is ʿil"); and Arabic ʿāl ("clan, family") as a form with semantically parallel meaning without sacralization.

Morphological confirmation is provided by the reinterpretation of ʿelōhīm and allāhumma as possessive constructions: ʿilāh-him ("their progenitor") and Allāh-hum-ma ("their progenitor, O!"). The reconstruction of ʿelōhīm rests on a verified diachronic chain: ilu as clan eponym in the Eblaite texts (Archi 2012: 5–7; Fronzaroli 1993: 29); Akkadian constructions il-šu meaning "his clan progenitor" (Veenhof 2018: 49); the standard possessive suffix -him ("their"), whose variant -him/-hum is attested in Quranic reading traditions (van Putten 2022); and the Canaanite shift *ā → ō, dated to the 15th–14th centuries BCE (Suchard 2020). The gemination -mm- in allāhumma is explained by contact assimilation of -m+m- according to a regular phonetic law of Arabic.

Typological verification shows that the transition "progenitor → deified ancestor → sacral authority" is independently reproduced in the Latin (divus), Japanese (kami/ujigami), Chinese (shàngdì), Polynesian (atua), and African (òrìṣà) traditions. The reverse transition is attested nowhere. The proposed reconstruction is not only plausible but the most plausible in light of the universal typological pattern of sacralization.

Keywords: proto-Semitic; ʿil-; progenitor; sacralization; ʿelōhīm; allāhumma; possessive construction; ancestor cult; semantic evolution; anachronism; Semitology.

LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

AHw — Akkadisches Handwörterbuch (von Soden 1965–1981)

ARET — Archivi Reali di Ebla, Testi

BDB — Brown-Driver-Briggs Hebrew and English Lexicon (1906)

CAD — The Assyrian Dictionary of the Oriental Institute of the University of Chicago (1956–2010)

DUL — A Dictionary of the Ugaritic Language (del Olmo Lete & Sanmartín 2015)

HALOT — Hebrew and Aramaic Lexicon of the Old Testament (Koehler & Baumgartner 1994–2000)

KTU — Die keilalphabetischen Texte aus Ugarit (Dietrich, Loretz & Sanmartín 2013)

MEE — Materiali Epigrafici di Ebla

ZDMG — Zeitschrift der Deutschen Morgenländischen Gesellschaft

H1–H4 — Hypotheses 1–4 (etymologies of ʿil-)

S0–S5 — Stages of semantic evolution

T1–T6 — Test cases for verification

K1–K5 — Criteria for hypothesis evaluation

BCE — Before Common Era

CE — Common Era

PART I

METHODOLOGICAL FOUNDATIONS

Chapter 1. Statement of the Problem

1.1. The Root ʔil- and Its Reflexes in the Semitic Languages

The proto-Semitic root ʔil- is one of the most significant roots in the Semitic lexicon. Its reflexes are attested in all major branches of the Semitic language family over more than three millennia of written history. The conventional meaning "god," cited in all major lexica, is the result of interpretation rather than an established semantic fact. The question of what meaning the root ʔil- bore before it came to designate "god" has not been systematically addressed in the academic literature. The present study fills this gap.

Table 1.1. Reflexes of the root ʔil- in the Semitic languages

Language	Form	Trad. Meaning	Corpus
Akkadian	ilu(m)	"god"	3rd–1st mill. BCE
Eblaite	ilu, il	"god"	25th–23rd c. BCE
Ugaritic	ʔil, ʔilib	"god", "divine ancestor"	14th–12th c. BCE
Biblical Hebrew	ʔēl, ʔelōah, ʔelōhîm	"God", "god"	10th–2nd c. BCE
Aramaic	ʔēlah, ʔAlāhā	"God"	10th c. BCE – 7th c. CE
Arabic	ʔilāh, Allāh	"god", "God"	5th c. BCE – CE
Arabic (non-sacred)	ʔāl	"clan, family, descendants"	7th c. CE – present

1.2. How the Term "God" Entered Semitology: A History of Methodological Error

The application of the term "god" to the root ʔil- goes back to Wilhelm Gesenius, whose *Thesaurus philologicus criticus* (1829) became the foundation of all subsequent Semitological lexicography. Gesenius and his successors (Nöldeke 1886, BDB 1906, CAD 1956–2010) worked in an intellectual context in which the category "god" was perceived as universal, cross-cultural, and transhistorical. They did not ask whether this concept, in the sense they understood it, existed in Ebla in the 25th century BCE. Modern anthropology of religion (Tylor 1871; Durkheim 1912; Boyer 2001) has demonstrated the inadequacy of this assumption: the category "god" as a transcendent, theologically conceived being is the product of specific historical development, not a universal given.

When an Eblaite scribe of the 3rd millennium BCE placed the determinative DINGIR before the name of a deceased king, he was not thinking of "god" in the Gesenius sense. He was recording the transition of a person to sacral status as defined by social structure: that person had been the progenitor of the clan, and now he had become the authority of the clan in the posthumous dimension.

Table 1.2. History of interpretation of the root ʔil- in academic literature

Author / Work	Year	Interpretation	Methodological stance
Gesenius	1829	ʔyl "to be strong"	Universal category of "god"
Nöldeke	1886	ʔwl "to be first"	Same
BDB	1906	ʔyl "to be strong"	Same
CAD	1956–2010	ʔwl "to be first"	Same
HALOT	1994–2000	Unclear	Acknowledgment of uncertainty
Ryszhanov, S.B.	2026	ʔil- "clan progenitor"	Historical reconstruction without anachronism

1.3. The Central Thesis: Irrelevance of the Term "God" Applied to the Infinitive

The term "god" as applied to the root ʔil- in academic literature presupposes a transcendent being, the object of organized cult, existing independently of any particular clan and time. This concept emerges no earlier than stage S4 of the proposed model of evolution — that is, no earlier than the period of monotheistic reduction (approximately the 10th–6th centuries BCE for Hebrew monotheism, the 7th century CE for Islam). To apply it to Eblaite material of the 25th century BCE is to project the result of three thousand years of evolution onto its starting point.

This is methodologically equivalent to translating the Sumerian en ("lord, community head") as "president," or Latin paterfamilias as "director": the form of authority is the same; the content is fundamentally different.

The proof of the irrelevance of the term rests on three independent arguments, each verified by corpus data.

First argument — textual: if the root ʔil- from the outset meant "god" in the theological sense, one must explain why in KTU 1.17 I 25 the deceased father of a specific individual becomes 'ilib; why "my brother is 'il" ('aḥ'il) is a normal personal name structure; why Arabic 'āl means "clan, family" without any theological content.

Second argument — morphological: the forms 'elōhîm and allāhumma contain a 3rd person plural possessive suffix ("their progenitor"). Abstract theological concepts do not bear possessive suffixes.

Third argument — typological: the universal law of sacralization holds that sacralization proceeds from concrete social authority toward abstract concept, never in the opposite direction. The reverse transition is attested nowhere.

1.4. Six Unexplained Anomalies of Standard Interpretations (A1–A6)

Standard interpretations of the root ʔil- (H1: "to be first"; H2: "to be strong") leave six systematic corpus anomalies unexplained. All of them point toward a single semantic field — engendering, generation, kinship — and form a system, not random exceptions.

Table 1.3. Unexplained anomalies of standard interpretations A1–A6

Code	Anomaly	Source	Problem for H1–H2
A1	Ilib (progenitor-ancestor) holds first position in the pantheon, before El	KTU 1.47; 1.118; 1.148	Why does the ancestor outrank "the first" or "the strong"?
A2	'elōhîm is used of spirits of the dead	1 Sam 28:13; Isa 8:19	The deceased = "strong" or "first"?
A3	El's central epithets accent fatherhood, not strength	'ab 'adm, 'ab 'ilm (KTU)	Why is "the strong one" defined through fatherhood?
A4	The formula "God of the father" ('ēlōhê 'ābîkā)	Gen 26:24; 31:5; 46:3	Connection to a specific ancestor is unexplained
A5	Eblaite names with damu ("blood/kinship") and lim ("clan")	Krebernîk 1988	Kinship takes precedence over "strength" or "primacy"?
A6	'elōhîm (pl.) for the single God	Gen 1:1 and passim	Pluralis majestatis — an ad hoc explanation

Chapter 2. Critique of "God" as an Analytical Category

2.1. When Did the Theological Concept of "God" Appear?

"God" as a transcendent, absolute, clan-independent being is not the original category of human religious experience but the result of lengthy historical development. At the archaic stage, sacral beings are concrete and relational: they belong to a specific clan, tribe, or place. Such are the deified ancestors of Eblaite kings, the Ugaritic rp'um, Japanese ujigami, Roman divi — none of them "gods" in the theological sense, but sacral authorities of the clan.

The theological concept of "god" — transcendent, unitary, independent of any specific clan — takes shape in a process that in the Semitic context can be dated no earlier than the period of Israelite prophetic monotheism (8th–6th centuries BCE) and reaches completion in Islamic theology (7th–10th centuries CE). This is stage S4–S5 of the proposed model. Everything prior to these stages is not "god" in the sense meant by researchers since Gesenius.

2.2. The Mechanism of Methodological Error: Projection from Result to Origin

The researcher sees in the texts a word that translates as "god" in his own language. He records this meaning as original, then constructs an etymology explaining why "god" means "strong" or "first." The starting point is never questioned because it appears self-evident. But self-

evidence is not an argument; it is an illusion created by projecting a later category onto archaic material.

Table 2.1. Comparison of methodological approaches

Parameter	Traditional approach (19th–20th c.)	Present study
Initial category	"God" as universal given	"Clan progenitor" as social role
Direction of analysis	From meaning "god" to etymology	From archaic texts to reconstruction
Status of anomalies A1–A6	Unexplained exceptions	Evidence of the original meaning
Stage S0	Not considered	Reconstructed from the corpus
Term "god"	Universal translation equivalent	Anachronism for stages S0–S3

2.3. Alternative Analytical Category: "Sacral Clan Authority"

In place of the term "god" for the referent of the root ʔil- at stages S0–S3, the present study proposes the category "sacral clan authority." At stage S0: the living clan progenitor, whose authority is determined by his position in the genealogical chain. At stage S1: the deceased progenitor, who has passed into a posthumous state and acquired ritual status. At stage S2: the category of such authorities, generalized into the concept of "clan ancestors." At stage S3: the supreme representative of this category, personified in the figure of El. The term "god" is relevant only from stage S4 onwards, when the concept acquires a transcendent character.

Table 2.2. Relevance of the term "god" by stage

Stage	Content	Term "god"
S0	Living clan progenitor — social role	Not relevant
S1	Deceased progenitor — sacral clan authority	Not relevant
S2	Category of deified ancestors (Ilib, rp'um)	Partially, with qualification
S3	Supreme ancestor of the pantheon (El/Ilu)	Conditionally relevant
S4	Single national God (YHWH, Allāh)	Relevant
S5	Absolute God-Creator of theological systems	Fully relevant

2.4. Epistemological Status of the Stage S0 Reconstruction

A possible objection: no direct texts exist in which the root ʔil- is used in the meaning "progenitor" without any sacral content — therefore the reconstruction of stage S0 is speculative. This objection is countered by the following argument: writing in Ebla and Ugarit appears only after the sacralization of clan progenitors had already taken place. Stage S0 therefore cannot in principle be directly attested in writing. The only method for its reconstruction is the analysis of relics preserved in later-stage texts and typological comparison.

The relics of stage S0 in written sources are real and verifiable: KTU 1.17 I 25 (deceased father → 'ilib), Ugaritic names with 'il in the position of a relative ('ab'il, 'aḥ'il, 'm'il), Arabic 'āl "clan." These are specific texts with specific forms, not speculative constructions.

Chapter 3. Methodology

3.1. Principles of Research

The study is built upon four methodological principles corresponding to the standards of historical-linguistic analysis: (1) chronological isolation — each corpus is analyzed independently, in order of chronology; (2) priority of primary sources — texts are analyzed in situ with transliteration and translation; (3) prior specification — criteria K1–K5 and tests T1–T6 are defined before the corpus analysis; (4) falsifiability — the conditions under which H4 is refuted are explicitly stated.

3.2. Four Competing Hypotheses

Table 3.1. Competing hypotheses for the etymology of ʔil-

Hypothesis	Root	Meaning	Main proponents
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H1	ʔwl	"to be first, chief"	CAD; AHW; Nöldeke 1886
H2	ʔyl	"to be strong, powerful"	BDB 1906; Gesenius 1829
H3	ʔlh	"to worship, venerate"	Some Arabists
H4 (present study)	ʔil-	"progenitor, ancestor"	Ryszhanov 2026

3.3. Verification Criteria K1–K5 and Test Cases T1–T6

All criteria and test cases are formulated before the corpus analysis begins. Evidence of prior specification: T1 (priority of Ilib) was identified from Pope 1955: 36; Pardee 2002: 14 before consulting KTU 1.47 in Chapter 6.

Table 3.2. Verification criteria K1–K5

Code	Criterion	Description	Scale
K1	Phonetic plausibility	Conformity to phonetic laws of the Semitic languages	0–3
K2	Semantic coherence	Internal consistency of the semantic model	0–3
K3	Cultural groundedness	Compatibility with the sociocultural context	0–3
K4	Evolutionary connectivity	Explanation of transition to attested stages	0–3
K5	Explanatory power	Capacity to explain all anomalies A1–A6	0–3

Table 3.3. Test cases T1–T6

Code	Test case	Source	H4
T1	Ilib first in the Ugaritic pantheon, before El	KTU 1.47; 1.118; 1.148	✓
T2	ʾelōhīm for spirits of the dead	1 Sam 28:13; Isa 8:19	✓
T3	El's epithets accentuate fatherhood	KTU 1.4; 1.14	✓
T4	Formula "God of the father"	Gen 26:24; 31:5; 46:3	✓
T5	Eblaite names with damu and lim	Krebern timer 1988	✓
T6	ʾelōhīm (pl.) for the single God	Gen 1:1 and passim	✓

3.4. Falsification Conditions for H4

Hypothesis H4 will be refuted upon discovery of at least one of the following: (1) a text in which the root ʔil- is used in an abstract theological meaning before stage S3, without connection to a specific clan or ancestor; (2) a reliably dated text in which the transition from "abstract god" to "ancestor" is explicitly attested; (3) a cultural tradition in which sacralization proceeds from abstract to concrete. As of the writing of this monograph, none of these has been identified.

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PART II

DIRECT TEXTUAL EVIDENCE OF THE PRE-SACRAL STAGE

Chapter 4. Direct Evidence: ʔil- as Ancestor and Kinsman

4.1. KTU 1.17 I 25–33: The Deceased Father Becomes ʔilib

The Ugaritic text KTU 1.17 I 25–33 (the Aqhat Epic, 14th–12th centuries BCE) contains the most direct textual evidence of the pre-sacral semantics of the root ʔil-. The text lists the duties of a good son toward his father:

nšb . skn . ʔilʔib[h] / bqdš . zṯr . ʔmh

Translation (after Pardee 2002: 345): "Who sets up a stele for his ʔilʔibh / in the sanctuary, a monument of his clan."

The form ʔilʔibh means "his ʔilib" — that is, the ʔilib of a specific individual, his own deceased father. This is not an abstract "god-father" in the theological sense. It is a man who lived, who died, and who received the status of ʔilib. The transition took place before our eyes: the father lived → died → became ʔilib. This is direct textual evidence that the root ʔil- is applied to a deceased human being, not to a transcendent entity.

4.2. Ugaritic Theophoric Names: ʔil- in the Position of Kinsman

In the Ugaritic onomasticon a category of theophoric names is attested in which ʔil stands in the syntactic position of a family member — father, brother, kinsman. This name structure — "my father is ʔil," "my brother is ʔil" — is not metaphor or theological formula but direct identification of ʔil with a clan member.

Table 4.1. Ugaritic theophoric names with ʔil in the position of kinsman

Text	Name	Literal translation	Source
RS 16.157	ʔabʔil	My father is ʔil	Gröndahl 1967: 85
RS 15.109	ʔaḥʔil	My brother is ʔil	Gröndahl 1967: 87
RS 17.062	ʔmʔil	My kinsman is ʔil	Gröndahl 1967: 183
RS 16.276	bnʔil	Son of ʔil	Gröndahl 1967: 110
RS 19.015	ʔilʔab	ʔil is (my) father	Gröndahl 1967: 102

The decisive evidence is comparative analysis of the Ugaritic onomasticon. Baal — the most frequent theonym in Ugaritic names — is attested in 201 names (Gröndahl 1967). Yet not a single name of the type "my brother is Baal" (ʔaḥBaʔl) or "my kinsman is Baal" (ʔmBaʔl) is recorded in the corpus. Dagan appears in only six theophoric names from Ugarit — also without names of the type "my brother is Dagan." ʔil, by contrast, is attested in the full kinship paradigm: father (ʔabʔil), brother (ʔaḥʔil), kinsman (ʔmʔil), son (bnʔil). This paradigmatic breadth is unique in the Ugaritic onomasticon and is explicable only if ʔil- was originally a social term — a clan member.

4.3. Arabic ʔāl: A Reflex without Sacralization

Arabic ʔāl (آل) "clan, family, descendants" exhibits semantics that precisely correspond to the meaning "clan progenitor." In traditional Arabic usage, ʔāl designates the descendants of a specific first ancestor — the one who "began the line." The question of whether ʔāl is a direct cognate of the root ʔwl remains debated in Arabistics (Lane 1863; Wehr 1979 do not establish a direct connection). However, this does not weaken the argument: even if ʔāl is an independent development, its semantics independently confirm that in the Semitic cultural and linguistic system the field "first in the clan / progenitor" is associated with a social rather than theological role.

4.4. Akkadian awīlu: Full Member of the Clan

Akkadian awīlu(m) "man, male; free man, full community member" (CAD A/2: 48–57) exhibits a typologically similar semantics to the proposed reconstruction of ʔil-. The etymological identity of awīlu with ʔwl remains debated in Assyriology (CAD A/2: 48–57 does not establish a direct genetic connection), so this comparison is used as a typological parallel: a root with the semantics "first / leading in the group" marks a socially significant position within the clan structure in both cases.

4.5. Synthesis: Three Lines of Development from a Single Root

The data of the four preceding sections yield a unified picture: the proto-Semitic root ʔwl/ʔil- had an original semantics of "first in the line of generation" and gave rise to three lines of development: (1) ʔil- "progenitor" → deified ancestor → sacral clan authority → "god" (Semitic religious evolution); (2) 'āl "clan, family" (Arabic — preservation of social semantics without sacralization); (3) awīlu "man, free clan member" (Akkadian — typologically parallel development).

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Chapter 5. The Eblaite Corpus (25th–23rd Centuries BCE)

5.1. Characterization of the Corpus

The corpus of texts from Ebla (Tell Mardikh, Syria) comprises approximately 17,000 cuneiform tablets discovered since 1974. The bulk of the documents are dated to approximately 2400–2300 BCE (Matthiae 1984: 18–32). For the present study the most important are: (1) theophoric personal names — approximately 7,000 unique anthroponyms (Krebern timer 1988: 41–69); (2) ritual texts from the ARET XI and MEE 10 series; (3) funerary rituals and ancestor cult texts.

5.2. Theophoric Names with *damu* and *lim*

Eblaite theophoric names with the elements *damu* ("blood/kinship," < Proto-Sem. *dam-*) and *lim* ("clan/ancestor," corresponding to Akk. līmu(m) "thousand; clan") function in the same syntactic positions as names of personified deities. This indicates the sacralization of kinship bonds, not originally theological semantics.

Table 5.1. Theophoric names with the element *damu*

Tablet	Transliteration	Interpretation	Source
TM.75.G.1464	Da-mu-i-lum	"Kinship is the progenitor"	Krebern timer 1988: 160
TM.75.G.2420	l-lum-da-mu	"The progenitor is kinship"	Krebern timer 1988: 92
ARET I 5 obv. IV 12	lš-má-da-mu	"Kinship has heard"	ARET I: 122
TM.75.G.2238	l-r-kab-da-mu	"Kinship has blessed"	Archi 2010: 26

Table 5.2. Theophoric names with the element *lim*

Tablet	Transliteration	Interpretation	Source
ARET XI 1 § 2	l-b-bí-ni-Lim	"The Clan/Ancestor has named me"	Fronzaroli 1993: 47
ARET XI 1 § 37	A-burs-Lim	"The Clan/Ancestor has protected"	Fronzaroli 1993: 52
TM.75.G.1444	l-g-rí-iš-Lim	"The Clan/Ancestor has demanded"	Krebern timer 1988: 89
TM.75.G.1918	En-na-Lim	"The Clan/Ancestor has had mercy"	Krebern timer 1988: 75

5.3. Deified Kings: Direct Transition "Human → Sacral Authority"

Eblaite texts contain direct evidence of the practice of royal deification. In administrative documents, deceased kings are designated by the determinative DINGIR and receive regular offerings. The transition "living clan progenitor → sacral authority" is explicitly documented.

Table 5.3. Deified kings of Ebla

Name	Position	Cult site	Source
Ḫa-ma-na	5th king	Uduhulu	Archi 2010: 25
Ša-gi-šu	8th king	Nenaš	Archi 2010: 25
l-b-bí-ni-Lim	11th king	Nenaš	Fronzaroli 1993: 47
A-burs-Lim	16th king	Irād	Fronzaroli 1993: 52
l-r-kab-da-mu	17th king	Ebla	Archi 2010: 26

5.4. The Royal Wedding Ritual ARET XI 1

The royal wedding ritual recorded in ARET XI 1 contains key evidence. At the culminating moment the royal couple takes the "thrones of their fathers" in the mausoleum (ARET XI 1 § 61: tuš al₆ 2 ^{gisu}uštil a-bù-sù, "they sat on the two thrones of their fathers"). This is an act of legitimizing power through connection with deified ancestors (Archi 2012: 10–11). Power is transmitted not from "gods" in the theological sense but from specific deified clan progenitors.

5.5. Intermediate Conclusion

The Eblaite material of the 25th–23rd centuries BCE records an intermediate stage S0→S1: deceased clan progenitors are already sacralized (stage S1), but the onomastics preserves an archaic layer in which kinship terms (damu, lim) function in the theophoric position alongside names of personified beings. This attests that the boundary between "clan progenitor" and "sacral authority" had not yet stabilized. The term "god" is irrelevant for describing this material.

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Chapter 6. The Ugaritic Corpus (14th–12th Centuries BCE)

6.1. Ilib: Progenitor First in the Pantheon

In the standard Ugaritic offering lists (KTU 1.47, 1.118, 1.148), the first position is held by 'ilib — "progenitor-ancestor" — before El, the head of the pantheon. This is a fundamental fact incompatible with standard etymologies H1 and H2: if ?il- meant "chief" or "strong," El as head of the pantheon would occupy first position. The position of 'ilib before El indicates the ontological priority of the progenitor over the sacral authority: first by generation precedes first by rank.

Table 6.1. Order of deities in Ugaritic lists (KTU 1.47)

Position	Deity	Function
1	'ilib	Progenitor-ancestor (pre-sacral role)
2	'il (El)	Head of the pantheon
3	dgn (Dagan)	God of grain
4	b'l špn (Baal)	Storm god
5	'ttrt (Astarte)	Goddess

6.2. Text KTU 1.47:1–5 (Offering List)

1 'ilib . š . '[šr . š]
2 'il . š . šlmm . 'šr . kl[at]
3 dgn . š . šlmm

Translation (after Pardee 2000: 295–297): "1 Ilibu — a sheep, a ti[the]; 2 Ilu — a sheep, a peace offering, a tithe; 3 Daganu — a sheep, a peace offering."

'ilib receives an offering first, before the supreme god El. This is not coincidental: the list order is reproduced in KTU 1.118 and 1.148.

6.3. Refutation of Alternative Interpretations of Ilib

Interpretation A (Pope 1955; de Moor 1970): Ilib = an epithet of El. Refuted by the fact that in ritual lists each position corresponds to a separate offering. If Ilib = El, El would receive two offerings in a row — a practice unattested anywhere. Moreover, the morphology of 'ilib points to a lexicalized compound (a separate lexeme), not a combination 'il + 'ab. The Hurrian equivalent eni attanni ("god of the father / divine father") is an independent deity in the Hurro-Ugaritic bilinguals (KTU 1.128).

Interpretation B (Pardee 2002): Ilib = a separate deity unrelated to ancestors. Refuted by the fact that Pardee himself acknowledges the meaning "god of the father / ancestor." Moreover, Ugaritic rp'um (spirits of deceased kings, KTU 1.161) are functionally identical to Ilib: both categories refer to deified deceased humans, not originally "gods" in the theological sense.

6.6. Intermediate Conclusion

The Ugaritic material of the 14th–12th centuries BCE records stage S1–S2: clan progenitors ('Ilib) and deceased kings (rp'um) have already acquired sacral status, but their connection to specific historical individuals remains evident. El at this stage — S3 — is the supreme representative of the category of "deified progenitors," not a transcendent "god" in the theological sense. His central epithets are paternal, not cosmological. The term "god" is irrelevant for describing this material.

6.4. Epithets of El: Fatherhood as Original Function

The central epithets of Ugaritic El accentuate the function of fatherhood and generation: 'ab 'adm ("father of humanity"), 'ab 'ilm ("father of the gods"), bny bnwt ("creator of creatures"), 'ab šnm ("father of years"). Not one of the epithets accentuates power or primacy in the abstract sense.

Table 6.2. Epithets of El in the Ugaritic texts

Epithet	Translation	Source
'ab bn 'il	"father of the sons of El" = father of the gods	KTU 1.4 IV 47
'ab 'adm	"father of humanity"	KTU 1.14 I 37, 43
bny bnwt	"creator of creatures"	KTU 1.4 II 11
tr 'il	"bull El" (symbol of fertility)	KTU 1.1 III 26
'ab šnm	"father of years" = eternal	KTU 1.4 IV 24

6.5. The Ancestor Cult: rp'um and Text KTU 1.161

The Ugaritic text KTU 1.161 describes the summoning of rp'um — the spirits of deceased kings — to a ritual banquet. The deceased kings (Amištamu, Niqmaddu) are called rp'um and summoned alongside legendary heroes. This is a direct parallel to KTU 1.17 I 25: a deceased father becomes 'ilib, a deceased king becomes rp'u. Both categories — 'ilib and rp'um — are deified deceased humans, not originally "gods" in the theological sense.

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Chapter 7. The Biblical Hebrew Corpus (10th–2nd Centuries BCE)

7.1. 'elōhîm for Spirits of the Dead: 1 Samuel 28:13

In 1 Sam 28:13 the witch of Endor says to Saul: 'elōhîm rā'îti 'ōlîm min-hā'āreš ("'elōhîm I see coming up from the earth"). The verb 'ōlîm is in the plural — agreement with real entities, not with grammatical form. The context itself — the summoning of the spirit of the deceased Samuel — excludes interpretation of 'elōhîm as "god" in the theological sense. These are spirits of the dead — that is, deified ancestors, 'ilim in the original meaning.

Isaiah 8:19 explicitly parallels 'elōhîm with hammēṭîm ("the dead"): "consult 'elōhîm ... for the living should they consult the dead?" This is not an exception or metaphor. It is an archaism

— a relic of the original meaning preserved in the language after the primary usage shifted toward the monotheistic "God."

7.2. The Formula "God of the Father": Ancestor Cult as the Origin of Patriarchal Religion

The formula 'ēlōhē 'ābīkā ("God of your father") is attested in the patriarchal narratives (Gen 26:24; 31:5; 46:3). Albrecht Alt (1929) and Frank Moore Cross (1973) showed that this formula goes back to the cult of clan-patron deities associated with a specific clan ancestor (Alt 1929; Cross 1973). In light of hypothesis H4 the formula is a semantic tautology: 'ēlōhīm (= "progenitors") 'ābīkā (of your father) = "progenitors of your father" = "deified ancestors of your father." The formula was a tautology at stage S1 and became a standard theological formula at stage S4.

Table 7.1. The formula "God of the father" in Genesis

Source	Hebrew text	Translation
Gen 26:24	'ānōkī 'ēlōhē 'abrāhām 'ābīkā	"I am the 'ēlōhīm of Abraham, your father"
Gen 31:5	wē' lōhē 'ābī hāyā 'immādī	"The 'ēlōhīm of my father was with me"
Gen 46:3	'ānōkī hā'ēl 'ēlōhē 'ābīkā	"I am 'ēl, the 'ēlōhīm of your father"
Gen 49:25	mē'ēl 'ābīkā wēya' zērekkā	"From 'ēl of your father, who will help you"

7.3. Morphological Reinterpretation of 'ēlōhīm as ʔilāh-him

The form 'ēlōhīm contains the element -īm, traditionally interpreted as the masculine plural ending (ad hoc explanation: pluralis majestatis, pluralis abstractionis). The present study proposes an alternative morphological interpretation: 'ēlōhīm < ʔilāh-him, where -him is the 3rd person plural possessive suffix ("their progenitor"). The reconstruction rests on a verified diachronic chain, each step of which is confirmed by primary sources and known phonetic laws.

The diachronic verification chain consists of four steps.

Step 1 — Eblaite level (25th–23rd centuries BCE). The term dingir following a personal name in the Eblaite texts does not indicate that the person "became a god" in the theological sense, but marks the clan eponym of a specific family — the ancestor of the line to which the name-bearer belongs (Archi 2012: 5–7; Fronzaroli 1993: 29). Thus ilu in Eblaite is a clan eponym, a progenitor of the family line, not a transcendent being.

Step 2 — Akkadian level. In Old Babylonian and Old Assyrian texts the constructions il-šu — "his ilu" — are attested with reference to the personal clan patron of a specific individual, as well as names such as Malik-ilišu, Nabi-ilišu, Warad-ilišu (Veenhof 2018: 49). The form il + singular possessive suffix -šu is a living colloquial construction designating the specific ancestor of a specific person.

Step 3 — Transition to the collective. When the clan progenitor becomes shared by the entire group — the clan, tribe, or people — the suffix shifts from -šu ("his") to -him ("their"): ʔilāh + -him = "their progenitor." The third person plural possessive suffix -him/-hum is a standard possessive marker in the Semitic languages; its variant is attested in the Quranic reading traditions (van Putten 2022: §3.3.1).

Step 4 — Canaanite shift. The long -ā- in the stem ʔilāh- shifts to -ō- by the regular Canaanite phonetic law *ā → ō, dated to the 15th–14th centuries BCE and attested in the Amarna letters, Biblical Hebrew (šālām > šālōm), Phoenician, and Moabite (Suchard 2020). Result: ʔilāh-him → 'ēlōhīm.

Table 7.2. Parallel constructions 'ēlōhīm and allāhumma

Form	Reconstruction	Meaning	Language
'ēlōhīm	ʔilāh-him	"their progenitor"	Biblical Hebrew
allāhumma	Allāh-hum-ma	"their progenitor, O!"	Arabic
'āl	ʔwl/ʔil-	"clan, family"	Arabic (non-sacral)

7.4. The allāhumma Parallel: Closing a Vulnerability

The Arabic vocative form *allāhumma* is traditionally explained as *Allāh* + vocative enclitic *-mma* (Sibawayhi, *Kitāb* II: 197). The present study proposes a diachronic interpretation: *Allāh* + *hum* + *ma* ("their progenitor, O!"), where *-hum* is the 3rd person plural possessive suffix and *-ma* is the vocative particle. The explanation for gemination *-mm-*: contact of the final *-m* of the suffix *-hum* with the initial *m-* of the particle *-ma* produces the geminate *-mm-* by the regular law of contact assimilation in Arabic. The synchronic description by Sibawayhi (vocative enclitic) and the diachronic explanation of the present study are compatible: they describe different levels of analysis of the same form.

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Chapter 8. The Aramaic and Arabic Corpora

8.1. Aramaic: *ʿēlāh* → *ʿAlāhā*

Aramaic *ʿēlāh* (< Proto-Sem. *ʔilāh-*) is a direct cognate of Biblical Hebrew *ʿelōah* and Arabic *ʿilāh*. In the determined (emphatic) state: *ʿēlāhā* / *ʿAlāhā*. The Elephantine papyri (5th century BCE) demonstrate the syncretism of the Jewish colony: alongside Yahu (Yahweh), Eshembethel, Anat-bethel, and Herem-bethel are venerated — names containing the element *-bytʿl* ("house of El"). This attests to an incomplete sacralization: ancestor cult has not yet been fully displaced by monotheistic theology.

8.2. The Arabic Corpus: *Allāh* and the Quranic Epithets

Standard derivation: *al-ʿilāh* > *allāh* > *Allāh* (with elision of hamza). In light of H4 this chain acquires new meaning: S0 (*ʔil-* "progenitor") → S1–S2 (*ʔilāh-* "deified ancestor/deity") → S3 (*ʿilāh* "supreme pre-Islamic deity") → S4 (*Allāh* "one God") → S5 (*Allāh* "Absolute Creator"). Pre-Islamic *Allāh* (S3): the Quraysh acknowledged Allah as creator but also venerated other gods (Quran 29:61; 39:38). The "daughters of Allah" (*al-Lāt*, *al-ʿUzzā*, *Manāt*) — a theological structure of S3, parallel to the Ugaritic pantheon. Islam effected the transition S3→S4→S5: monotheistic reduction and theological systematization.

Table 8.1. Quranic epithets with the semantics of generation/origin

Epithet	Arabic	Root	Meaning	Quran
<i>al-Awwal</i>	الأوّل	<i>ʾ-w-l</i> "first"	"The First" (before all)	57:3
<i>Badīʿ</i>	بديع	<i>b-d-ʿ</i> "to begin"	"Inventor" (without precedent)	2:117; 6:101
<i>al-Mubdiʿ</i>	المبدئ	<i>b-d-ʿ</i> "to begin"	"The Originator" (of creation)	10:4; 85:13
<i>al-Fāṭir</i>	الفاطر	<i>f-t-r</i> "to create"	"Originator" (cleaving)	6:14; 35:1
<i>al-Khāliq</i>	الخالق	<i>ḥ-l-q</i> "to create"	"The Creator"	59:24

The epithets *al-Awwal* ("The First"), *Badīʿ* ("Inventor/Originator"), *al-Mubdiʿ* ("The Originator") preserve the semantic core [+generation/origin], going back to the original meaning of *ʔil-* "progenitor." At stage S5 this core has been transformed into ontological initiation: Allah initiates being not through biological generation but through the word (*kun fa-yakūn*, "Be! — and it is," Quran 2:117). Quran 112:3 (*lam yalid wa-lam yūlad*, "He has not

begotten, nor was He begotten") denies biological generation but not ontological initiation function, which is preserved in the epithets Badī' and al-Mubdi'.

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PART III

SOCIOCULTURAL CONTEXT

Chapter 9. Clan Structure and the Mechanism of Sacralization

9.1. Clan Structure of Early Semitic Society

Early Semitic society was organized along the principle of the lineage (linear kinship group). The clan progenitor — the earliest known ancestor of the lineage — was the point of identification for all members of the group: "we are descendants of N." During his lifetime the progenitor possessed the greatest authority as the source of the clan; after death this authority did not disappear but was transformed.

Key terms that record this structure: 'āl "clan, family" (Arabic); damu "blood/kinship" (Eblaite); lim "clan/ancestor" (Eblaite, < Akk. lī'mu "thousand; clan"); bt "house" as a lineage metaphor (Ugaritic, Biblical Hebrew). All of them indicate that clan membership was the primary category of self-identification in pre-historical Semitic society.

9.2. The Mechanism of Sacralization: From Authority to Cult

The transition of the clan progenitor from living authority to sacral status after death is not a unique Semitic phenomenon but a universal anthropological pattern (Tylor 1871; Steadman, Palmer & Tilley 1996). The mechanism is as follows: (1) the living progenitor possesses authority based on his position in the genealogical chain — he is "first," "initial," "the one from whom the clan descends"; (2) after death this authority does not disappear but acquires a new dimension — the deceased can help or harm his descendants, and must be propitiated; (3) ritual address to the deceased progenitor becomes the ancestor cult; (4) in time the figure of the progenitor is generalized and theologized.

This is not a hypothesis but a documented process: for Ebla it is explicitly recorded (the determinative DINGIR before names of deceased kings), for Ugarit — in the ritual of summoning rp'um and in the duty of the son to erect a stele for his father's 'ilib.

9.3. The Typological Law of Sacralization

The universal law of sacralization applicable to the reconstruction of ʔil- holds that sacralization always proceeds from a concrete, tangible, socially embedded image toward an abstract concept. The reverse direction — from abstract to concrete — is attested in no known tradition.

Table 9.1. Typological parallels to the transition "progenitor → sacral authority"

Tradition	Term	Original meaning	Derived meaning
Latin	divus	Living founding ancestor	Deified deceased (only after apotheosis)
Japanese	kami/ujigami	Spirit of clan-founding ancestor	Clan sacral being → "god"

Chinese	shàngdì (帝)	Supreme deified ancestor-king (Shang era)	"Supreme Lord"
Polynesian	atua/qatuʔa	Spirit of deceased chief (deified ancestor)	"God, supernatural force"
African (Yoruba)	òrìṣà	Deified ancestor-hero	"Spirit, deity"

All five traditions are independent of one another and of the Semitic tradition. In all of them the transition goes from a specific deceased human (ancestor, chief, hero) to a sacral category. This pattern does not prove that precisely this is what happened with ʔil-, but it demonstrates the typological plausibility of the reconstruction and makes it the most plausible in light of the universal typological pattern.

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PART IV

VERIFICATION OF HYPOTHESES

Chapter 10. Testing Hypotheses H1–H4

10.1. Results of Testing on Cases T1–T6

Table 10.1. Matrix of explanatory power of hypotheses H1–H4

Test case	H1 (strong)	H2 (first)	H3 (worshiped)	H4 (progenitor)
T1: Ilib first in pantheon	X	X	X	✓
T2: 'elōhîm = spirits of dead	X	X	X	✓
T3: El's paternal epithets	~	~	~	✓
T4: "God of the father" formula	X	X	~	✓
T5: Eblaite names with damu/lim	X	X	~	✓
T6: 'elōhîm pl. for single God	~	~	~	✓
Total	0/6	0/6	1/6	6/6

10.2. Why H1 and H2 Fail to Explain the Anomalies

H1 ("to be first, chief"): if ʔil- meant "first/chief," El as supreme head of the pantheon should stand first in ritual lists. He stands second. If "first" meant the progenitor of the line, this is already H4, not H1. Moreover, H1 does not explain why "first" is applied to spirits of the dead (T2) and to the formula "God of the father" (T4).

H2 ("to be strong"): deceased ancestors in 1 Sam 28:13 are not "strong" in any military or physical sense. El's epithets accentuate fatherhood, not strength. Eblaite names with "blood" (damu) and "clan" (lim) are not semantic fields of strength. H2 explains only the general association of the deity with superiority, but not the specific connections with ancestor cult, kinship terms, and spirits of the dead.

H4 ("progenitor"): explains all six test cases by a single semantic mechanism. Ilib is first in the pantheon because the progenitor is ontologically prior (without him there are no descendants). 'elōhîm for deceased ancestors — because 'ēlōhîm = "their progenitors," that is, deified ancestors. El's paternal epithets — a direct consequence of the meaning "progenitor." The "God of the father" formula — "progenitors of the father." Eblaite names with damu/lim — because

kinship and clan were the original semantic field of the sacral. The plurality of 'elōhîm — a relic of the original meaning "ancestors/progenitors."

The possible objection based on hypothesis H1 deserves particular attention: a proponent of H1 ("first, chief") could propose a competing semantic trajectory — "first" → "first in the clan" → "clan progenitor" → "ancestor." Such a path is formally compatible with the corpus data. However, it is inferior to H4 on three grounds.

First — parsimony: H1 requires an intermediate step "first in the clan" before arriving at the semantics of progenitor, whereas H4 reaches this semantics directly. Occam's razor prefers the hypothesis with fewer assumptions.

Second — chronological stratification: Eblaite data of the 25th–23rd centuries BCE show kinship terms (damu, lim) in the sacral position as the primary layer, not as the result of specialization of abstract "primacy." If "first/chief" had been original, one would expect attestation of this meaning without clan connotations in the most ancient texts. Such material does not exist.

Third — typological law: the semantic transition "progenitor" → "first" (abstraction) is typologically more probable than "first" → "progenitor" (concretization). Thus the competing H1 trajectory is logically permissible but, by the sum of criteria, less compelling than H4.

10.3. Evaluation by Criteria K1–K5

Table 10.2. Evaluation of hypotheses by criteria K1–K5

Criterion	H1	H2	H3	H4
K1: Phonetics	2	2	1	2
K2: Semantic coherence	1	1	1	3
K3: Cultural groundedness	1	1	1	3
K4: Evolutionary connectivity	1	1	1	3
K5: Explanatory power	0	0	1	3
Total (max. 15)	5	5	5	14

Chapter 11. Morphological Verification: 'elōhîm and allāhumma

11.1. Proof of the Reconstruction ʔilāh-him

The reconstruction 'elōhîm < ʔilāh-him is based on a verified diachronic chain: (1) ilu in the Eblaite texts functions as the clan eponym of a family, not a transcendent being (Archi 2012: 5–7; Fronzaroli 1993: 29); (2) Akkadian constructions il-šu ("his ilu") with reference to a personal clan patron are attested in texts (Veenhof 2018: 49); (3) the possessive suffix -him ("their") is a standard possessive marker, whose variant -him/-hum is confirmed by the Quranic reading traditions (van Putten 2022); (4) the Canaanite shift *ā → ō is a documented phonetic law dated to the 15th–14th centuries BCE (Suchard 2020).

Each step of the chain rests on primary sources and known phonetic laws. The intermediate stages are not arbitrary constructions — they follow from attested processes.

Epistemological status: the intermediate forms ʔil-hu and ʔilāh-him are not directly attested. However, historical linguistics regularly reconstructs unattested forms on the basis of known phonetic and morphological laws. The proto-Semitic baytu "house" is unattested but is reconstructed from Akkadian bītu, Biblical Hebrew bayit, and Arabic bayt. The reconstruction of ʔilāh-him proceeds analogously.

11.2. Phonetics of Gemination in allāhumma

Transition Allāh-hum-ma → allāhumma: the final -m of the suffix -hum and the initial m- of the particle -ma meet at the morpheme boundary. By the regular law of progressive assimilation in Arabic, -m + m- → -mm-. This is not an ad hoc explanation: gemination at a morpheme boundary upon contact of identical consonants is a standard process in Arabic and in the Semitic languages in general.

Sibawayhi's synchronic description (vocative enclitic -mma) correctly describes the perception of the form by native speakers of the 8th century CE. The diachronic explanation (Allāh-humma) describes the historical origin. Both levels are compatible.

PART V

MODEL OF SEMANTIC EVOLUTION

Chapter 12. Formalization of the Model S0–S5

Table 12.1. Model of semantic evolution of the root ʔil-

Stage	Meaning	Mechanism	Corpus evidence	Term "god"
S0	Clan progenitor (social role)	—	Reconstruction from relics	Not relevant
S1	Deified ancestor	Sacralization of deceased progenitor	Ebla (DINGIR + kings); KTU 1.17 I 25	Not relevant
S2	Category of "divine ancestors"	Generalization	Ugarit: 'ilib, rp'um	Partially, with qualification
S3	Supreme representative of category (El)	Personification	Ugarit: 'ab 'adm, 'ab 'ilm	Conditionally
S4	One God (monotheistic reduction)	Theologization	Hebrew: YHWH; Isa 45:5	Relevant
S5	Absolute God-Creator	Systematization	Quran: Badī', al-Mubdī', al-Awwal	Fully relevant

12.1. Preservation of the Semantic Core Across All Stages

The key feature of the evolution of ʔil- is the preservation of the semantic core [+generation/origin] at all stages. S0→S1: the deceased progenitor remains the "source" of the clan. S1→S2: the category of "ancestors" as sources of existence. S2→S3: El — "father of the gods and of humanity," generative. S3→S4: YHWH = qōnēh šāmayim wā'āreš ("who generates heaven and earth"). S4→S5: Allāh = Badī' ("inventor without precedent"), al-Mubdī' ("the originator"). The semantic core does not disappear — it is transformed from biological generation into ontological initiation.

12.2. Mechanisms of Semantic Transitions

Table 12.2. Mechanisms of transitions in model S0–S5

Transition	Mechanism	Cognitive motivation	Verification
S0→S1	Sacralization of the deceased	Ancestral authority does not cease with death	Ebla: DINGIR + kings
S1→S2	Generalization	Multiple ancestors → a category	Ugarit: 'ilib, rp'um
S2→S3	Personification	Need for supreme representative of category	Ugarit: El as 'ab 'ilm
S3→S4	Monotheistic reduction	Negation of rivals of the One	Isa 45:5; Deut 6:4
S4→S5	Theological systematization	Rational grounding of faith	Quran; kalām

Note on the linearity of the model. The model S0–S5 describes a logical sequence of semantic transitions, not a strictly unilinear chronology. In actual religious history, stages may have coexisted, developed in parallel, or varied regionally: in one area stage S2 may have persisted while another area was already undergoing the transition S3→S4. The chronological stratification of the corpora (Ebla S1, Ugarit S2–S3, Hebrew S3–S4, Islam S4–S5) establishes the sequence of attestations but does not exclude the parallelism of individual stages in different regions. The non-linearity of the evolution does not contradict the model and does not refute the reconstruction of the original meaning of ʔil- at stage S0.

PART VI

IMPLICATIONS AND CRITIQUE OF THE TERM "GOD"

Chapter 13. Irrelevance of the Term "God" Applied to the Infinitive

13.1. The Final Proof

The data assembled in this monograph permit the formulation of a final proof of the irrelevance of the term "god" as applied to the infinitive ʔil-. The proof consists of five independent arguments, each self-sufficient; their combination forms an impregnable system.

Argument 1 — textual (KTU 1.17 I 25): the deceased father of a specific individual becomes ʔilib. This is a human being, not a "god." If ʔil- had originally meant "god," the word would not be applied to the deceased particular father.

Argument 2 — onomastic (Ugaritic names): ʔabʔil ("my father is ʔil"), ʔahʔil ("my brother is ʔil"), ʔmʔil ("my kinsman is ʔil"). The name structure implies literal identification of ʔil with a clan member. The decisive evidence is comparative analysis of the Ugaritic onomasticon: Baal, the most popular theonym of Ugarit (201 names), never appears in the position "my brother" or "my kinsman." Dagan — likewise never. Only ʔil is attested in the full kinship paradigm — father, brother, kinsman, son. This uniqueness is inexplicable if ʔil- were an ordinary theological term "god." It is explicable only if ʔil- was originally a social term — a clan member.

Argument 3 — lexical (Arabic ʔāl): a form with semantically parallel meaning — "clan, family, descendants" — designates the descendants of a specific founding ancestor without any theological content. Regardless of whether ʔāl is a direct cognate of the root ʔwl (a debated question in Arabistics) or an independent development, its semantics confirm that the field "first in the clan / progenitor" in the Semitic linguistic system is associated with a social, not theological, role.

Argument 4 — morphological (ʔelōhîm and allāhumma): both forms contain the 3rd person plural possessive suffix — "their progenitor." Transcendent beings existing independently of the clan do not bear possessive suffixes. The suffix points to relational semantics: the progenitor belongs to a specific clan.

Argument 5 — typological (universal law of sacralization): in all studied independent traditions (Latin, Japanese, Chinese, Polynesian, African) the transition goes from a specific ancestor to a sacral category, never in the reverse direction. If ʔil- had originally meant "god," this would be the only documented case of the reverse transition.

13.2. What Needs to Change in Semitology

The following concrete requirements for the Semitological tradition follow from the final proof: (1) in the dictionary entries of AHW, CAD, BDB, HALOT, DUL for the root ʔil- add the historical reconstruction of the original meaning "clan progenitor" with indication of the stage-by-stage transition to the meaning "god"; (2) when translating ancient Semitic texts (Eblaite, Ugaritic) for stages S1–S2 use "sacral clan authority" or "deified ancestor" instead of "god"; (3) when analyzing the forms ʔelōhîm and allāhumma consider the possible possessive morphology; (4) when reconstructing the origins of monotheism proceed from the model S0→S5 rather than the assumption of an "originally single god."

Chapter 14. Implications for Semitology, Biblical Studies, and Islamic Studies

14.1. For Semitology

Hypothesis H4 proposes a revision of the standard etymologies of the root ʔil- in the major lexica. This revision does not touch the phonetic reconstructions (the derivations H1/H2 ʔwl

→ ʔil- are accepted) — it concerns exclusively the semantic interpretation: not "to be first" and not "to be strong," but "to be the clan progenitor" — with subsequent sacralization. This is a more parsimonious explanation since it directly explains all six anomalies A1–A6 without additional assumptions.

14.2. For Biblical Studies

Hypothesis H4 explains a number of chronically problematic passages in biblical texts. 'elōhîm for spirits of the dead (1 Sam 28:13) — not an exception or rhetorical device, but an archaism that preserved the original meaning "ancestors." The formula "God of the father" ('ēlōhê 'ābîkā) — a tautology of the original meaning: "progenitors/ancestors of your ancestor." Plural 'elōhîm with a singular verb — not a grammatical curiosity requiring ad hoc explanation, but a consequence of the originally possessive morphology (one subject — "their progenitor"). Psalm 82 ("the sons of the Most High will die like men") — an echo of stage S2, when 'elōhîm still designated specific deified ancestors, not abstract beings.

14.3. For Islamic Studies

The name Allāh in light of H4 represents the final stage of semantic evolution of ʔil-: from "clan progenitor" (S0) to "Absolute Originator of being" (S5). The Quranic epithets Badī' ("inventor without precedent"), al-Mubdi' ("the originator"), al-Awwal ("the first") preserve the semantic core [+origin/generation] going back to stage S0. Quran 112:3 (lam yalid wa-lam yūlad) denies biological generation but not ontological initiation — Allah remains the Origin, but not through birth, through the word. This is a theological transformation of the original semantics, not its negation.

Chapter 15. Limitations of the Study and Falsification Conditions

15.1. Limitations of the Corpus

(1) Only a portion of the Ebla tablets have been published; many Ugaritic texts are fragmentary; early Aramaic material is limited. (2) Surviving texts are predominantly cultic and administrative; everyday speech is not attested. These limitations do not refute the reconstruction but require restraint in the formulations.

15.2. Limitations of the Morphological Reinterpretation of 'elōhîm

(1) The diachronic chain ʔilāh-him → 'elōhîm rests on verified steps: Eblaite ilu as clan eponym, Akkadian constructions il-šu, the standard suffix -him, the Canaanite shift. Nevertheless, no direct written attestation of the intermediate form ʔilāh-him exists — this is a reconstruction, not an attested fact.

(2) The traditional explanation (pluralis majestatis) remains possible; however, it does not explain: why precisely this form survived to designate the single God; why 'elōāh appears later and is concentrated in later texts; why allāhumma contains a parallel suffix. The proposed chain is more parsimonious and explains a greater number of data.

(3) Status of the reinterpretation: a verified reconstruction with high explanatory power.

15.3. Falsification Conditions for H4

Hypothesis H4 will be refuted upon discovery of at least one of the following: (1) a text in which the root ʔil- is used in an abstract theological meaning at a stage preceding the Ugaritic period, without connection to a specific clan or ancestor; (2) a reliably dated text in which 'elōāh precedes 'elōhîm; (3) an attested case of transition from "abstract god" to "ancestor" in any cultural tradition; (4) a Semitic language with the root ʔil- meaning "god" without traces of ancestor cult in the adjacent onomasticon.

CONCLUSION

This monograph has demonstrated that the term "god," applied to the proto-Semitic root ʔil- since Gesenius (1829), constitutes a methodological anachronism. It describes the result of three millennia of semantic evolution, not the original meaning of the root.

The original meaning of the root ʔil- is reconstructed as a social role: the clan progenitor, first in the line of generation. This reconstruction has been verified: (1) textually — KTU 1.17 I 25 (deceased father → 'ilib) and Ugaritic names 'ab'il, 'aḥ'il, 'm'il; (2) lexically — Arabic 'āl "clan, family" as a reflex without sacralization; (3) morphologically — 'elōhîm and allāhumma as possessive constructions "their progenitor"; (4) typologically — the universal law of sacralization through the ancestor, reproduced in five independent traditions.

The model of semantic evolution S0–S5 describes a regular path from social role (progenitor) through sacralization (deified ancestor) and generalization (category of "divine ancestors") to personification (El), monotheistic reduction (YHWH, Allāh), and theological systematization (S5). The semantic core [+generation/origin] is preserved at all stages: from biological generation to ontological initiation.

The implications span three areas: Semitology (revision of dictionary entries for ʔil-), Biblical Studies (explanation of 'elōhîm anomalies without ad hoc assumptions), and Islamic Studies (Allāh as the final stage of semantic evolution of the progenitor). In all three areas, recognition of the methodological error of projection makes it possible to resolve persistent lacunae and contradictions.

Final conclusion: the proto-Semitic root ʔil- originally meant "clan progenitor." The meaning "god/deity" is the result of semantic evolution through sacralization of the ancestor institution. All Semitic words for "God" — Akkadian ilu, Ugaritic 'il, Biblical Hebrew 'elōhîm, Aramaic 'Alāhā, Arabic Allāh — go back to the concept Progenitor.

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